

Introduction: Are we asking the right questions?

One of the things that has always interested me about executive decision-making is how two experienced leaders can look at exactly the same situation, have access to much the same information, understand the same organisational challenges and yet arrive at very different conclusions about what should be done.

We often explain these differences in terms of experience, personality, leadership style or the quality of the information available. Sometimes these explanations are sufficient. But I think there is something more fundamental happening. Executives do not simply process information and evaluate alternatives. They interpret the world around them through deeply embedded beliefs and assumptions about what is right, what matters, what they are responsible for and what they believe they can influence.

This raises an interesting question: before we start evaluating our choices, have we sufficiently examined the way we see the situation in the first place?

I was recently reminded of this while considering the Cartesian Decision Framework, a relatively straightforward but useful approach to decision-making. It encourages us to consider four questions: What will happen if I do something? What will not happen if I do it? What will happen if I do not do it? And what will not happen if I do not do it?

At first glance, this might seem like another decision-making matrix. However, its value lies in something quite important. It forces us to consider not only the consequences of taking action but also the consequences of doing nothing. In organisational settings, particularly during periods of transformation, this is often where some of the most difficult executive judgements reside.

We spend considerable time considering the risks of changing something. We are sometimes less inclined to consider the risks of leaving things as they are.

But this also got me thinking about a question that goes beyond the decision matrix itself. How do executives determine which consequences matter in the first place? And how do they exercise judgement when the consequences of their decisions cannot be known with certainty?

Decision-making and executive judgement: There is a difference

Most management decision-making frameworks are designed to help us structure our thinking. They provide ways of identifying alternatives, assessing risks, comparing possible outcomes and selecting a preferred course of action. There is considerable value in this. Good decision processes can reduce unnecessary complexity and help executives avoid decisions based purely on instinct or immediate pressures.

However, there is a distinction between making a decision and exercising judgement.

Decision-making is concerned with evaluating alternatives and selecting a course of action. Executive judgement involves something deeper. It concerns how we interpret the circumstances confronting us, determine what deserves our attention, establish what is important and decide what constitutes an appropriate or defensible response.

In other words, judgement does not simply happen when we select an option. It is already at work when we decide what the problem actually is, whose interests should be considered and which consequences deserve the greatest weight.

Consider two executives confronted with an organisation facing declining competitiveness and the need for significant digital transformation. Both understand the financial implications. Both recognise the competitive pressures. Both have access to the same strategic analysis.

The first executive may regard rapid transformation as an institutional necessity. Without it, the organisation risks becoming irrelevant. The second may agree that transformation is necessary but be deeply concerned about the impact on employees, existing stakeholder relationships and the organisation's institutional responsibilities.

Neither executive is necessarily wrong. They are interpreting the same circumstances through different evaluative orientations.

This is where I believe our understanding of executive judgement needs to extend beyond conventional decision-making techniques.

The role of executive worldviews

Through my research into organisational change and executive behaviour, I have become increasingly interested in the role that worldviews play in shaping how executives interpret and respond to complex organisational circumstances.

A worldview is not simply a collection of opinions or personal preferences. It provides a deeper orientation through which we make sense of the world around us. It influences what we consider legitimate, what responsibilities we recognise and how we perceive our capacity to influence events.

The Worldview LOA framework brings three interconnected dimensions into focus: Legitimacy, Obligation and Agency. Together, these offer a way of understanding the evaluative orientations that inform executive judgement.

Legitimacy concerns what we believe is right, appropriate and defensible. When confronted with a difficult organisational decision, executives make judgements about what is legitimate, whose interests should be recognised and what can reasonably be justified. These assessments are not always straightforward. A decision that makes strategic or financial sense may still raise questions about fairness, institutional values or the distribution of consequences.

Obligation concerns what we believe we ought to do. Executive leadership is fundamentally relational. Our decisions affect employees, customers, shareholders, communities and the institutions within which we operate. Executives carry different responsibilities towards these stakeholders, and these responsibilities do not always align neatly. The challenge is not simply to recognise competing obligations but to determine how they should be interpreted and prioritised in particular circumstances.

Agency concerns what we believe we can do. It is one thing to recognise that a particular course of action is legitimate and that we have a responsibility to pursue it. It is quite another to believe that we possess the capacity, influence, resources or authority to make it happen. Our perceptions of agency shape how we respond to constraints, uncertainty and opportunities for intervention.

What makes these three dimensions particularly interesting is that they are interconnected. An executive might believe that a particular transformation is legitimate and that there is an obligation to pursue it, yet perceive insufficient agency to make it happen. Another might possess considerable authority and resources but question whether exercising that authority would be appropriate.

Together, Legitimacy, Obligation and Agency provide a deeper understanding of the evaluative orientations informing executive judgement.

The missing dimension: Judgement under uncertainty

There is, however, another dimension that deserves attention. Much of our thinking about executive decision-making assumes that, with sufficient information and appropriate analytical tools, we can reduce uncertainty to a level that allows us to make an informed choice.

But what happens when we cannot?

Organisational transformation rarely takes place under conditions of complete information. Digital disruption, emerging technologies, changing markets and shifting stakeholder expectations create

circumstances in which executives must make judgements about futures that have not yet materialised. Even the most sophisticated forecasting and risk-management processes cannot eliminate this uncertainty.

I was particularly interested in this while considering Nathan Furr and Susannah Harmon Furr's book, *The Upside of Uncertainty: A Guide to Finding Possibility in the Unknown*. Their central proposition is that uncertainty should not necessarily be viewed as something to eliminate or avoid. It can also be a source of possibility, discovery and transformation.

This is an important perspective for executive leadership. We often approach uncertainty through the language of risk, mitigation and control. These are necessary considerations, but they can also limit our ability to recognise what might become possible when established arrangements are disrupted.

Consider an organisation confronted with a technological development that threatens its existing business model. One executive may see the disruption primarily as a threat to organisational stability. Another may see an opportunity to rethink the business model, explore new markets and create entirely different sources of value.

The uncertainty is broadly the same. What differs is the way the executives interpret it.

This brings us back to Worldview LOA. Our perceptions of legitimacy, obligation and agency influence not only how we evaluate known alternatives but also how we interpret possibilities that have not yet become apparent.

An executive's worldview can therefore influence whether uncertainty is experienced primarily as a threat, an obligation to respond, an opportunity to explore or a constraint on action.

Uncertainty does not merely test executive judgement; it exposes the worldview orientations through which that judgement is formed and exercised.

Seeing possibility: Reframing uncertainty

One of the practical contributions of Furr and Furr is their four-part approach to developing what they call uncertainty ability. They organise their tools around four categories: Reframe, Prime, Do and Sustain.

The first, Reframe, encourages us to reconsider how we interpret uncertainty. Rather than automatically seeing the unknown as a threat, we learn to explore alternative perspectives and recognise possibilities that might otherwise remain hidden.

I find this particularly interesting in relation to Legitimacy.

What makes a particular opportunity worth pursuing? Why do we regard one possible future as desirable and another as unacceptable? What assumptions inform our understanding of what is appropriate or legitimate?

Consider an organisation whose established operating model is under pressure from digital disruption. An executive who sees the existing model as central to the organisation's identity may interpret technological change as a threat to institutional legitimacy. Another may regard the same disruption as an opportunity to redefine how the organisation creates value.

Reframing is therefore more than changing the language we use to describe uncertainty. It involves examining the assumptions through which we construct our understanding of a situation.

Perhaps one of the most important executive capabilities is the ability to recognise that our first interpretation of a situation is not necessarily the only defensible one.

Preparing for uncertainty: Understanding our bearings

The second category, Prime, concerns preparation. Furr and Furr encourage individuals to understand their strengths, vulnerabilities and different orientations towards risk.

Executives often have a reasonably sophisticated understanding of organisational risk, but considerably less awareness of how their own underlying orientations influence the way they perceive and respond to that risk.

An executive may be comfortable with financial risk but highly sensitive to reputational risk. Another may be willing to challenge established business practices but reluctant to disturb institutional relationships. A third may be comfortable with strategic experimentation but uncomfortable with the possibility of losing personal influence or authority.

These orientations influence how executives approach uncertain circumstances, sometimes in ways that are not immediately apparent to them.

Worldview LOA provides a useful starting point for this kind of reflection. Understanding what we regard as legitimate, recognising the obligations we perceive and examining our sense of agency can help us become more conscious of the assumptions informing our responses.

It also creates an opportunity for more productive executive dialogue. When leadership teams recognise that their members may interpret uncertainty differently, disagreement becomes something that can be explored rather than simply managed.

The objective is not to create executives who all see the world in the same way. Different perspectives can be an important organisational resource. The challenge is to understand where those differences originate and how they influence collective judgement.

Acting without certainty: The relationship between judgement and agency

Perhaps the most challenging aspect of navigating uncertainty is moving from understanding a situation to doing something about it.

In organisational settings, there is often a tendency to delay action until sufficient information is available. Executives commission further analysis, request additional forecasts and seek greater reassurance before committing to a course of action.

There are certainly circumstances where caution is necessary. However, in complex and rapidly changing environments, complete certainty may never arrive.

This creates a particular challenge for executive judgement. Leaders must often make decisions without knowing precisely what the consequences will be.

The third category in Furr and Furr's framework, Do, offers an interesting response. Rather than treating action as a single, high-stakes commitment, it encourages experimentation, incremental progress and learning through experience. Small actions can generate information that was previously unavailable. They can test assumptions, reveal unexpected opportunities and help executives adapt their understanding as circumstances evolve.

This is closely connected to Agency within Worldview LOA.

Agency is not simply about having authority or occupying a senior position. It concerns how executives perceive their capacity to influence circumstances and contribute to outcomes.

An executive may recognise the legitimacy of an opportunity and perceive a responsibility to pursue it, but still feel unable to act because of institutional constraints or uncertainty about their own influence. Equally, an executive may have considerable authority but remain reluctant to exercise it.

The relationship between judgement and action is therefore more complex than simply deciding what should be done. It involves developing a sufficiently informed sense of agency to act despite uncertainty.

This has important implications for understanding change-supportive behaviour. Recognising the need for organisational transformation does not automatically translate into a willingness or capacity to support it. The evaluative orientations informing an executive's understanding of legitimacy, obligation and agency influence whether strategic recognition becomes commitment and action.

In this sense, the ability to act without certainty is not the absence of judgement. It is an expression of judgement under conditions where certainty is unavailable.

Sustaining the journey: The relational and human dimensions of uncertainty

The fourth category, Sustain, introduces another important dimension: the emotional and relational experience of uncertainty.

Executive leadership is frequently portrayed as requiring confidence, decisiveness and composure. There is often an implicit expectation that leaders should provide certainty for others, even when they themselves are navigating unfamiliar territory.

Yet uncertainty affects everyone, including those in leadership positions.

Transformation initiatives can create anxiety, disrupt established relationships and challenge deeply held assumptions about organisational identity and individual roles. When things do not go according to plan, executives must manage not only the strategic consequences but also the human responses that follow.

Furr and Furr recognise the importance of resilience, emotional awareness, connection and the capacity to learn from setbacks. Their framework reminds us that things do not always work out as anticipated. Sometimes setbacks are part of the learning process. At other times, they indicate that a different direction is required.

This has an interesting connection with Obligation.

Executive obligations are not limited to achieving strategic or financial outcomes. They also involve recognising the people and relationships affected by organisational decisions. The responsibility to pursue transformation must be considered alongside the responsibility to support those who experience its consequences.

It is possible to be strategically correct in recognising the need for change and yet exercise poor judgement in how that change is pursued.

Sustaining transformation therefore requires more than perseverance. It requires an ongoing willingness to reconsider what is appropriate, recognise the consequences of our actions and remain responsive to the people involved.

The Cartesian Decision Framework: Considering the consequences of action and inaction

The relationship between uncertainty and executive judgement also brings us back to the Cartesian Decision Framework.

Its four questions provide a useful way of examining the consequences of acting and not acting. However, there is an additional consideration when we introduce uncertainty: the consequences themselves are not always predictable.

Executives must therefore distinguish between what they know, what they assume and what remains unknown.

A decision matrix can help structure the evaluation, but it cannot remove the uncertainty surrounding the possible outcomes. Nor can it determine which consequences should receive the greatest weight.

This is where the combination of the Cartesian framework and Worldview LOA becomes particularly valuable.

The Cartesian framework encourages executives to consider the implications of alternative courses of action. Worldview LOA helps explain how executives interpret those implications and establish what constitutes a defensible response.

Consider again the executive deciding whether to proceed with a major digital transformation. The Cartesian questions encourage consideration of what might happen if the organisation proceeds, what opportunities might be lost by proceeding, what might happen if it delays and what might be lost through inaction.

Worldview LOA introduces a deeper enquiry. Is the transformation legitimate? What obligations does the executive perceive towards employees, customers and the institution? Does the executive believe there is sufficient agency to implement the transformation responsibly?

The uncertainty perspective adds another question: what possibilities might emerge that cannot yet be fully anticipated?

The three perspectives therefore contribute different but complementary elements to executive judgement. Consequence analysis structures the evaluation. Worldview LOA provides insight into the underlying

evaluative orientations. Uncertainty ability encourages executives to remain open to possibilities, learn through action and adapt as circumstances evolve.

Two executives could complete precisely the same decision matrix and still arrive at different conclusions. Their differences may lie not in their ability to understand the consequences but in the way they interpret legitimacy, prioritise obligations, perceive agency and respond to the unknown.

The Executive Sextant: Developing judgement in uncertain waters

The relationship between worldviews, uncertainty and executive judgement also informs the development of the Executive Sextant and the broader Voyage of Executive Judgement.

The metaphor of navigation is deliberate.

When navigating unfamiliar waters, it is not enough to know where you want to go. You need to establish your position, understand your bearings, interpret the conditions around you and determine how best to proceed. You may have a destination in mind, but the actual journey will require continuous interpretation, adjustment and judgement.

Executive leadership in complex organisational environments is not very different.

Worldview LOA provides the evaluative bearings through which executives interpret their circumstances. The Executive Sextant provides a reflective process for examining how those bearings inform judgement and how judgement translates into action.

The four capabilities described by Furr and Furr offer a useful practical complement to this process. Reframe encourages executives to see differently. Prime encourages them to prepare. Do encourages them to experiment and act. Sustain encourages them to learn, adapt and persevere.

I would not treat these four capabilities as substitutes for the LOA dimensions. They address different questions. Reframe, Prime, Do and Sustain describe practical ways of engaging with uncertainty. Legitimacy, Obligation and Agency help explain the underlying evaluative orientations through which executives interpret and respond to it.

Indeed, each of the four capabilities can be informed by all three LOA dimensions.

An executive reframing uncertainty must consider what possibilities are legitimate, what obligations accompany them and what can realistically be achieved. Preparing for uncertainty requires an understanding of personal and organisational agency, but also of the responsibilities and principles that should guide preparation. Taking action involves assessing what is appropriate, what ought to be done and what can be influenced. Sustaining the journey requires continued reflection on obligations, legitimacy and the capacity to adapt.

This creates an opportunity to integrate practical uncertainty-navigation tools into a broader process of executive development without diluting the theoretical contribution of Worldview LOA.

The objective is not to produce executives who are comfortable with every form of uncertainty. It is to develop executives who can recognise their own evaluative orientations, engage constructively with different perspectives and exercise reasoned judgement when familiar reference points are no longer sufficient.

A different starting point for organisational transformation

I believe the implications extend beyond individual executive development.

Organisations increasingly operate in environments characterised by technological disruption, institutional complexity, competing stakeholder expectations and unpredictable transformation pathways. In these circumstances, established management practices remain important, but they cannot guarantee the answers executives need.

The challenge is not simply to develop better forecasting techniques or more sophisticated risk-management processes. It is also to develop the collective capacity to interpret uncertainty, recognise emerging possibilities and act responsibly when outcomes cannot be fully predicted.

This requires organisations to recognise that uncertainty is not experienced uniformly. Executives, managers and employees bring different worldviews to the same circumstances. These differences influence how they interpret the need for change, what they perceive as legitimate, which obligations they prioritise and how much agency they believe they possess.

Understanding these differences can improve the quality of organisational dialogue and create opportunities for more meaningful engagement with transformation.

Rather than immediately asking why people resist a particular change, we might first ask how they are interpreting the circumstances and what underlying beliefs inform their responses.

Rather than assuming that a lack of action reflects a lack of commitment, we might explore whether people perceive the proposed intervention as legitimate, whether they recognise an obligation to support it and whether they believe they have the capacity to contribute.

These questions take us beyond the familiar language of resistance management and towards a deeper understanding of the evaluative processes informing organisational behaviour.

Key takeaways

There are several important implications for executives navigating organisational complexity and transformation.

First, decision-making and executive judgement are not the same. Decision frameworks help us evaluate alternatives, but judgement shapes how we interpret circumstances and determine what matters.

Second, worldviews influence how we experience uncertainty. Executives may encounter identical circumstances but interpret the threats, possibilities and responsibilities very differently.

Third, Legitimacy, Obligation and Agency provide important evaluative bearings. They help explain what executives consider right, what they believe they ought to do and what they perceive themselves capable of achieving.

Fourth, inaction deserves as much scrutiny as action. Waiting for certainty can itself carry significant organisational consequences and may result in opportunities being lost.

Fifth, recognising the need for change does not automatically produce action. Executives must also develop the conviction, perceived obligation and sense of agency to translate judgement into behaviour.

Finally, uncertainty should not always be treated as something to eliminate. It can be a source of possibility, learning and transformation, provided executives develop the capacity to interpret, navigate and respond to it.

Conclusion: The capacity to navigate what we cannot know

One of the most compelling ideas in *The Upside of Uncertainty* is that uncertainty is not simply an obstacle standing between us and the future we want. It is often the very condition through which new possibilities become accessible.

Furr and Furr provide a useful set of practical tools for engaging with this reality. Reframing, preparing, acting and sustaining are valuable capabilities for individuals, teams and organisations navigating an unpredictable world.

However, I believe there is another dimension worth considering. How we engage with uncertainty is influenced by how we see the world. Our underlying beliefs about legitimacy, obligation and agency shape what we perceive as possible, what we believe we ought to do and what we think we can achieve.

This is the contribution that Worldview LOA seeks to make to our understanding of executive judgement.

It moves the conversation beyond the practical question of how to navigate uncertainty and towards the deeper question of how executives interpret the unknown and form judgements within it.

Perhaps the objective of executive development should not be to create leaders who are comfortable with certainty, but leaders who can exercise sound judgement when certainty is no longer available.

After all, the most significant opportunities for transformation rarely arrive with a complete set of instructions. They emerge in circumstances where the familiar no longer provides sufficient direction and where the future must, at least in part, be discovered through action.

The challenge for executives is therefore not simply to manage the unknown, but to recognise the possibilities within it, understand the worldviews informing their judgements and develop the agency to act responsibly.

Executive judgement begins before we evaluate our choices. It begins with how we see the world, what we believe is legitimate, what we perceive ourselves to be obligated to do and what we believe we are capable of achieving.

Transformation begins not with changing the world, but with changing the way we see it.